Furthermore, this perceived lack of a clear European identity (or simply the advent of a new identity) opened the window wide not only to various conspiracy theories, but also to radical and extreme positions. It also offered a suitable explanation of political developments, statements and European Parliament declarations that Eastern Europeans found it difficult to subscribe to. In fact, in the view of many in Central Europe, repeated difficulties with the European constitution, the Conference on the Future of Europe, and the European Commission's portfolio for the European way of life were proof of Europe being unsure about what it is and what it stands for. E.g., the Letter of Intent, a policy document accompanying the EU State of the Union 2022 document, lists under the heading of 'Promoting our European Way of Life' the following items: mental health, recognition of qualifications, digitalisation of travel documents, facilitation of travel, combating child sexual abuse and cybersecurity skills academy. These are hardly attributes of a distinct culture or way of life.[107]

Krastev, probably the leading thinker on these issues in Central Europe, seems to share the concern when he talks about the time *after Europe* in which 'Europe is suffering from an identity crisis in which its Christian and Enlightenment legacies are no longer secure'.[108] It is important to note that he does not refer only to Christianity (which Orbán could do too), but also to Enlightenment: it is not just about the Christian heritage – to which so many in the liberal West may be averse – but classic liberalism is in decline too. However, this identity crisis seems to worry – rightfully so – the advocates of liberal democracy when it comes to (right-wing or conservative) populism in Eastern Europe, but less so when faced with a radical liberal or leftist, post-modern or 'woke' agenda in the West. In their view, the danger to liberal democracy comes from the socially conservative side only.

The stage was thus set – in the most inconvenient way possible – for the next scene, that of the mass arrival in 2015-16 of migrants, largely Syrians from Turkey, coming via Greece, and from there to Western Europe, through the Balkans or via Hungary. There, Prime Minister Viktor Orbán insisted on the EU asylum and migration rule-book, pointing out that the situation was untenable, and seizing the opportunity to sound the alarm about the impending overflow of Europe by Muslim migrants. Islamic terrorism that shook Europe in the early 2000s (the Madrid 2004 and